

# Course Study Guide

*Trimester 2 2026 | A companion guide to how this course runs — read alongside the Course Profile*

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This guide explains how the course is organised day to day: where to find material, how assessments and groups work, how lab sessions run, and how to get help. It is a living document — sections will be added and refined as the trimester progresses, so check back on Canvas for the latest version.

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## 1. Teaching Materials

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All teaching materials for this course are available from the course Canvas home page.

The most important materials are the lecture slides for each week. These define the content scope for all assessments: if a topic is not covered in the lecture slides, it will not be assessed, and everything that is in the slides is fair game for assignments.

For most topics we also provide extra readings. These are optional — they exist for students who want to explore a topic in more depth, but they are not essential for completing any assessment, and you will not be disadvantaged for skipping them.

## 2. Keeping Materials Up to Date

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The teaching team makes every effort to keep all teaching materials aligned with the latest LTS (Long-Term Support) version of the technologies used in the course. For example, this trimester (2026) the course uses Java 25, whereas the 2025 offering used Java 21.

Despite our best efforts, some material, code examples, or screenshots may still reference an older version. All content should be compatible with the current version specified for this trimester.

### **Found something outdated?**

*If you notice any material that uses an outdated or incompatible version — of Java, IntelliJ, JavaFX, or any other tool — please report it to the course convenor so it can be corrected for everyone.*

## 3. Course Assessments

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There are three assessment items in this course:

| Item                          | Weight | Due / Format                          |
|-------------------------------|--------|---------------------------------------|
| Assignment — Milestone 1      | 20%    | End of Friday, Week 5                 |
| Assignment — Final Submission | 40%    | End of Friday, Week 11                |
| Final Exam                    | 40%    | Individual, closed-book, via ProctorU |

Both assignments are group-based, but each student's individual mark may be adjusted based on the peer review process — see the Peer Review Guidelines for full details.

### 3.1 The Final Exam

The final exam is individual and closed-book, sat online through ProctorU. You are permitted one page of notes (A4, double-sided), which may be printed, handwritten, or a mix of both.

### **Hurdle requirement for master students**

*Master students (7010ICT) must score at least 40% in the final exam to pass the course, regardless of their overall mark.*

Exam questions are drawn at random from the same question bank used for the weekly lab quizzes, so practising the lab quizzes each week is directly useful preparation for the final exam.

A practice exam is released near the end of the trimester. Its question types and distribution match the real final exam, so use it to practise and get a sense of how you are likely to perform.

## 4. Assignments and Groups

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This section covers how assignment groups are formed and administered. For assessment weights and due dates, see Section 3 (Course Assessments).

## 4.1 Forming Your Group

Groups are formed during the first lab session — please attend and follow your lab tutor's instructions to enrol into a group.

- Enrol into a group using the Canvas group enrolment link.
- Undergraduate students (2006ICT) must also add their group's registration details to the shared online spreadsheet. This gives students a more visible way to find and join a suitable group.
- A group can have no more than 5 students. The scope of the assignments is designed for a group of 4 or 5.
- Keep the same group for the entire trimester — groups are not reformed between Milestone 1 and the Final Submission.

The earlier you settle into a stable group, the earlier you can start building the assignments.

## 4.2 Group Leader

Every group must nominate a leader, who is responsible for:

- Submitting the assignment on behalf of the group.
- Collecting peer review ratings and calculating each member's average peer rating (see the Peer Review Guidelines for full details).

## 4.3 Late Submission and Extensions

If your group cannot submit an assignment on time, apply for an extension rather than submitting late without approval.

- 3 days or less: ask your lab tutor to approve the extension directly.
- More than 3 days: apply through Griffith's official assignment extension application process.

### **Keep written evidence of the approval**

*Whichever path you use, you must include written evidence of the approval — the approval email, or a screenshot of the Teams conversation — in your submission. Without it, the late penalty may still be applied even if you were verbally told it was approved.*

Late submissions without an approved extension are penalised according to the University's late submission policy: 5% of the available marks deducted per calendar day late, down to 0 marks once the submission is more than 7 days late.

## 4.4 Assignment Marking and Feedback

Your lab tutor is the assessor for your assignments — contact them directly with questions about your mark or feedback. You should expect your assignment to be marked within two weeks of the submission due date.

If you disagree with a mark, first discuss it with your lab tutor. If the disagreement cannot be resolved, escalate it to the course convenor. Keep all discussion of the dispute in writing (email or Teams) so there is a clear record.

## 4.5 Solo (Single-Member) Groups

Some students, for various reasons, prefer to complete the assignments on their own. We strongly discourage this, for two reasons:

- 1 The workload for the assignments is substantial and is scoped for a team of 4–5. Every student in previous trimesters who chose to work alone regretted the decision.

- 2 Working alone means missing out on the team-based working experience that is typical in industry — one of the key skills this course is designed to develop.

***If you still want to work solo***

*You must email the course convenor for approval and provide valid reasons for the request. Approval is not automatic.*

## 5. Academic Integrity

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### 5.1 General Principles

You are free to discuss your assignment within your group and with the teaching team, and you are permitted to use AI tools (see below). What is not allowed is directly copying work from another group, or from any source outside your group, and submitting it as your own.

***The final exam is closed-book***

*Cheating in the final exam will be prosecuted and could result in failing the course entirely.*

### 5.2 Using AI to Study and Complete Assignments

Students are allowed, and encouraged, to use AI tools to help them study and complete the assignments. AI tools are already widely used across the IT industry, so the ability to use them effectively is an essential skill for a modern software engineer — this course treats that skill as part of what you are here to learn. You may use AI to generate code, polish your written reports, and verify your results.

***But using AI doesn't replace studying***

*You are expected to thoroughly understand every topic covered in this course, and to be able to read, explain, and verify all of the source code in your submission — including code an AI tool generated for you. If you use AI to generate code, you are expected to understand the function of every line, and every symbol, in that code. If you don't, you will eventually reach a point where your AI tool can't help you solve the problem, because you won't be able to tell it what's actually wrong.*

This isn't just a course requirement — it reflects how AI is used well in industry. Based on industry experience, more experienced programmers consistently use AI tools far more efficiently than less experienced ones, precisely because they understand what the tool is producing and can direct, check, and correct it.

### 5.3 AI and the Final Exam

***AI is not permitted in the final exam***

*The final exam is worth 40% of your grade and is closed-book. You are not permitted to use AI tools during the exam.*

## 6. Lab Sessions

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### 6.1 How Lab Time Is Used

Labs run for two hours each week. Attendance is not mandatory, and lab time is used flexibly based on what each group needs:

- The lab tutor may lead a short activity for the whole class, where useful.
- Most of the two hours is unstructured time: groups discuss assignment progress, individuals work through the week's lab exercises, and anyone can ask the tutor for help with the assignment or lab exercises.

## 6.2 Lab Exercises

Each week's lab exercises are designed to help you practise and build the skills covered that week. They are:

- Not assessed.
- Expected to be completed individually.

Completing every exercise in full can be time-consuming, so solutions and walkthrough videos are provided for every lab. Feel free to refer to these if you find an exercise too difficult to complete on your own — and feel free to discuss the exercises with your teammates, or ask for help from your lab tutor or the course convenor directly.

Each lab also includes a set of lab quizzes. These draw from the same question bank as the final exam (see Section 3.1), so working through them every week is one of the most direct ways to prepare for the exam.

## 6.3 Group Progress Checks

In some weeks, the lab tutor may conduct a group check — a short review of each group's progress on the current assignment. This is not compulsory, but we encourage you to treat it as a valuable opportunity to get feedback on your progress directly from your tutor.

# 7. Getting Help and Support

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The teaching team's role is to support and help you learn. We are open to requests — if you are finding a concept difficult, would benefit from more worked examples or another walkthrough video, or notice a problem with the existing materials, please tell us.

- During lab sessions — ask your lab tutor.
- Outside of labs — contact the course convenor by email or Teams.

You can usually expect a response within one working day. If more than 3 days pass with no reply, it likely means your message was missed rather than ignored — please resend it.